

INTERNATIONAL A-LEVEL ENGLISH LITERATURE

Unit 4A Literary representations

Wednesday 14 January 2026 07:00 UK Time Time allowed: 2 hours 30 minutes

Materials

For this paper you must have:

- an OxfordAQA 12-page Answer Book.

Instructions

- Use black ink or black ball-point pen.
- Write the information required on the front of your answer book.
- Do all rough work in your answer book. Cross through any work you do not want to be marked.
- You must answer **all** questions. There is **one** question in Section A and **one** question in Section B.

Information

- The maximum mark for this paper is 50.
- The marks for questions are shown in brackets.
- You will be marked on your ability to:
 - use good English
 - organise information clearly
 - analyse carefully the writers' methods
 - use specialist vocabulary where appropriate.

Section A: Prose

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Read the following extract carefully. It is taken from the opening of *The Siege of Krishnapur*, a novel by J G Farrell, first published in 1973.

Krishnapur is a fictional Indian town. The events of the novel take place in 1857, during the time of the Indian Rebellion. At this time, India was under the control of the British-based East India Company. Later in the novel, the rebellion reaches Krishnapur.

Write an analysis of this extract, in which you focus on the significance of the representation of race, class and culture.

[25 marks]

Anyone who has never before visited Krishnapur, and who approaches from the east, is likely to think he has reached the end of his journey a few miles sooner than he expected. While still some distance from Krishnapur he begins to ascend a shallow ridge. From here he will see what appears to be a town in the heat distorted distance. He will see the white glitter of walls and roofs and a handsome grove of trees, perhaps even the dome of what might be a temple. Round about there will be the unending plain still, exactly as it has been for many miles back, a dreary ocean of bald earth, in the immensity of which an occasional field of sugar cane or mustard is utterly lost.

The surprising thing is that this plain is not quite deserted, as one might expect. As he crosses it towards the white walls in the distance the traveller may notice an occasional figure way out somewhere between the road and the horizon, a man walking with a burden on his head in one direction or another . . . even though, at least to the eye of a stranger, within the limit of the horizon there does not seem to be anywhere worth walking to, unless perhaps to that distant town he has spotted; one part looks quite as good as another. But if you look closely and shield your eyes from the glare you will make out tiny villages here and there, difficult to see because they are made of the same mud as the plain they came from; and no doubt they melt back into it again during the rainy season, for there is no lime in these parts, no clay or shale that you can burn into bricks, no substance hard enough to resist the seasons over the years.

Sometimes the village crouches in a grove of bamboo and possesses a frightful pond with a water-buffalo or two; more often there is just a well to be worked from dawn till dusk by the same two men and two bullocks every single day in their lives. But whether there is a pond or not hardly matters to the traveller; in either case there is no comfort here, nothing that a European might recognise as civilisation. All the more reason for him to press on, therefore, towards those distant white walls which are clearly made of bricks. Bricks are undoubtedly an essential ingredient of civilization; one gets nowhere at all without them.

But as he approaches he will see that the supposed town is utterly deserted; it is merely a melancholy cluster of white domes and planes surrounded by a few trees. There are no people to be seen. Everything lies perfectly still. Nearer again, of course, he will see that it is not a town at all, but one of those ancient cemeteries that are called 'Cities of the Silent', which one occasionally comes across in northern India. Perhaps a rare traveller will turn off the road to rest in the shade of a mango grove which separates the white tombs from a dilapidated mosque; sometimes one may find incense left smouldering in an earthenware saucer by an unseen hand, but otherwise there is no life here; even the rustling leaves have a dead sound.

Krishnapur itself had once been the centre of civil administration for a large district. At that time European bungalows had been built there on a lavish scale, even small palaces standing in grounds of several acres to house the Company representatives of the day who lived in magnificent style and sometimes even, in imitation of the native princes, kept tigers and mistresses and heaven knows what else. But then the importance of Krishnapur declined and these magnificent officials moved elsewhere. Their splendid bungalows were left shuttered and empty; their gardens ran wild during the rainy season and for the rest of the year dried up into deserts, over whose baked earth whirlwinds of dust glided back and forth like ghostly dancers.

Glossary

shale: a type of rock

dilapidated: in need of repair

bungalow: a single-storey house

Turn over for Section B

Section B: Poetry

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Read carefully the following poem, 'Apotheosis at the Signing Table' by Clive James, published in 2017. The poem describes a book-signing session in the university city of Cambridge, England. It is described from the point of view of the writer, Clive James. Waterstones and Heffers are famous bookshops.

Write an analysis of this poem, in which you focus on the significance of the representation of a writer in old age.

[25 marks]

Apotheosis at the Signing Table

Looking ahead for places to sit down,
Come spring I might, one last time, limp downtown
And into Heffers, into Waterstones,
In either order, haul my creaking bones,
To stand, with a long-practised half-lost look,
Somewhere beside the stack of my new book
Until I'm asked to sign. As if surprised
I'll sit down, slowly, seeming paralysed
By sheer humility as they bring stock
Of books that I forgot I wrote. I'll sign
Each tempting title-page with my by-line
Like a machine for hours on end. The clock
Will seem not to exist. My signature
Will grow, however, steadily less sure,
Until, the felt-tip quivering in my grasp,
I scrawl the hieroglyphs of my last gasp.
A final short sip from my cup of tea
And I will topple, croaking tragically.
Slumped on the carpet, I will look around,
And all the walls of books in the background,
More splendid even than they were before,
Will seem to hear my small voice from the floor.
'Heffers or Waterstones, this is goodbye,
But I rejoice that I came here to die,
So one day those who know my books may say
That this is where he signed his life away.'

Glossary

apotheosis: glorification of someone, raising them almost to divine status, in this case used ironically

by-line: the line under a newspaper article which gives the name of the writer

hieroglyphs: 1. writing system used in ancient Egypt 2. (informal) writing that is hard to read

croaking: 1. the noise made by a frog 2. (informal) dying

signed his life away: 1. spent his last hours signing his name 2. gave up his rights to something

END OF QUESTIONS

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